Foreword to the Rails 7 Edition

It’s been a long time since Ruby on Rails was the new kid on the block, but it’s more relevant than ever for developing websites and services. After more than sixteen years since its original release, Rails continues to mature as a platform that helps you get things done.

One of the secrets of Rails is something that its creator, David Heinemeier Hansson, calls conceptual compression. A careful building and layering of abstractions let you quickly start a task. Then, if and when you need to go deeper and take more control of a particular aspect of Rails, you can. You’ll see this in every facet of Rails. For example, ActiveRecord—Rails’ database layer—helps you quickly get data in and out of databases yet allows you to drop down to SQL when needed.

Another secret of Rails is that it builds on Ruby’s emphasis on optimizing programmer happiness. It makes the process of creating software for the web fun and rewarding.

What isn’t a secret is what Rails allowed programmers to do. Some of the biggest software success stories of the last two decades were built and launched on Rails. Shopify, the company I currently work for, is one of those success stories. The same codebase that Tobi Lütke started in 2006, shown in the image, has grown up to serve millions of merchants and process billions of dollars of transactions a week. And we’re still using Ruby on Rails, with no plans to ever quit using it. While we use many other technologies, and will continue to evaluate new ones, Rails and—more importantly—the principles it is built on are at the core of what we do.